3 Transitive and Intransitive Verbs

Revision

A. You know that a sentence can be divided into two parts:
(i) the *subject* and (ii) the *predicate*. (See Book 3, Chapter 10)

B. To find the subject of a verb, we ask the question: *who* or *what* + the predicate? The answer to that question tells us who or what the subject is. (See Book 4, Chapter 9, pp 43–44)

C. You have also been told that we shall use the word *subject* to refer to the *simple subject*, *subject word* or *subject words*.

D. The predicate must contain a finite verb. It may consist of a finite verb only.
Boys play. (Subject: *Boys* | Predicate: *play*)
Boys are playing football. (Subject: *Boys* | Predicate: *are playing football.*)

E. The predicate often consists of a finite verb and other words.

Subjects and Verbs

1. Look at the following examples:

   (a) *Kalyan wrote an essay.*

   (b) *This old man sells flowers.*

   (c) *The terrible flood will destroy all the crop.*

   (a) *Who* + wrote an essay (predicate)? Ans: *Kalyan*
   Kalyan, therefore, is the subject of the verb *wrote*.

   (b) *Who* + sells flowers (predicate)? Ans: *(This old) man*
   Therefore, the subject of the verb *sells* is *man.*

(c) *What* + will destroy all the crop (predicate)? Ans: *(The terrible) flood*
So, *flood* is the subject of the verb *will destroy*.

If you look at sentences *(a)*, *(b)* and *(c)* carefully, you will notice that in each of them the subject itself *did*, *does* or *will do* something.

In *(a)*, the verb *wrote* tells us what Kalyan did.

In *(b)*, the verb *sells* tells us what this old man does.

In *(c)*, the verb *will destroy* tells us what the flood will do.

So, the person or thing which *did, does* or *will do* something is the subject of the verb. In other words, it is the subject which *acts*.

2. Now, look at the same sentences written in a different way:

(d) *The essay was written by Kalyan.*
(e) *Flowers are sold by this old man.*
(f) *All the crop will be destroyed by the terrible flood.*

Again, to find the subject, we ask:

(d) *What* + was written by Kalyan? Ans. *(The) essay*
So, *essay* is the subject of the verb *was written*.

(e) *What* + are sold by this old man? Ans. *Flowers*
Flowers, therefore, is the subject of the verb *are sold*.

(f) *What* + will be destroyed by the flood? Ans. *(All the) crop*
So, *crop* is the subject of the verb *will be destroyed*.

Can you tell the difference between sentences *(a)*, *(b)*, *(c)* and sentences *(d)*, *(e)*, *(f)*?

In *(d)*, the subject—*essay*—did not do anything.

In *(e)*, the subject—*flowers*—does not do anything.

In *(f)*, the subject—*crops*—will not do anything.

These subjects *do not act*—something is *done to* them, or they are *acted upon* by somebody or something else.

You must, therefore, remember that just as verbs may be used to tell us what some persons or things *do,* they may also be used to tell us what *is done to* some persons or things.

3. A verb may not refer to an action—it may simply tell us what a person or thing *is*:

(g) *The rose is red.*

(h) *London is a big city.*

(i) *Kunal is very lazy.*

Transitive Verbs

When the subject of a verb acts and the action *affects* another person or thing, that is, somebody or something different and separate from the subject, that person or thing is called the ***object*** of the verb. In other words, the action *starts from* the subject and *ends with* the object:

action (verb)

subject → → → → → → → → → → → → **object**

(j) *Farmers till the soil.*

(k) *Jack kicked the football.*

(l) *Father will clean the table.*

In *(j)*, the farmers' action—*tilling*—affects the *soil*—a thing *different and separate* from the farmers themselves. We can also say that the action of *tilling* passes from the farmers to the *soil*. So, *soil* is the object of the verb *till*.

Similarly in *(k)*, Jack's action of *kicking* affected something *separate and different* from Jack himself—*football*. So, *football* is the object of the verb *kicked*.

In *(l)*, Father's action of *cleaning* will affect a thing that is *separate and different* from Father himself—the *table*. So, *table* is the object of the verb *will clean*.

A verb which has an object is known as a transitive verb.

To find out whether a verb has an object, we ask the question *what* or *whom* after the verb:

Farmers till *what/whom?* Ans: *soil*

Jack kicked *what/whom?* Ans: *football*

Father will clean *what/whom?* Ans: *table*

So, *soil*, *football*, *table* are objects of the verbs *till*, *kicked*, *will clean*.

Here are some more examples:

(m) Sushma ate an apple.	*ate* what/whom?	Ans: *apple*
(n) He drives a car.	*drives* what/whom	Ans: *car*
(o) I shall sing a song.	*shall sing* what/whom	Ans: *song*

So, *apple, car, song* are objects of the verbs *ate, drives, shall sing*.

It is very important to remember that, as in all the above examples, the object has to be somebody or something different from the subject itself.

Secondly, as in the case of the subject, the object may have other words qualifying it, like *the* in *(j), (k), (l)* or *a/an* as in *(m), (n), (o)*. We usually use the word *object*, to refer to the *object-word* or *object-words*, not to these qualifying words. It must be remembered, however, that the object may in many cases consist of words which cannot be separated from one another, that is, they act as a single unit.
(See Chapters 9 and 10.)

Intransitive Verbs

Often, the verb simply tells us something about the subject itself: what it *does*, what it *is*, or what it *is like*. The action described by the verb does not affect some other person or thing—it stops with the subject:

action (verb)

subject → → → → → → → → → → → → → **subject**

(p) The dog barked.

(q) Birds fly.

(r) John will play.

In *(p)*, the verb *barked* simply tells us something about the *dog*, the subject itself. It does not tell us how the subject's action affected some other person or thing. The verb *barked*, therefore, has no object.

Similarly in *(q)*, we are told something about the subject itself. The action of *flying* does not pass from *Birds* to some other thing or person. The verb *fly*, therefore, has no object.

In *(r)*, the verb *will play* does not affect any person or thing other than the subject itself: the action of *play* stops with *John*, the subject. So, the verb *will play* has no object.

> A verb, which does not have an object, is known as an intransitive verb.

Now, look at these examples:

(s) The man looks ill.

(t) The journey will be difficult.

(u) Javed became a doctor.

In each case, if we ask the question *what* after the verb, we seem to get an answer:

The man looks *what*?	Ans: *ill*
The journey will be *what*?	Ans: *difficult*
Javed became *what*?	Ans: *a doctor*

But, if we look at the answers carefully, we find that each of them tells us something about the subject itself and does not refer to somebody or something that is different and separate from the subject. So, *ill, difficult, doctor* are not really objects. As they help the verbs to complete what the verbs say about the subjects, they are called *complements.*

All these verbs—*looks, will be, became*—are, therefore, intransitive.

In order to find out whether a verb has an object or not, we have to do two things:

First, we ask the question *what* or *whom* after the verb.

- If we do not get an answer, we can straightaway say that the verb is intransitive.
- If we get an answer, we have to look closely at the answer to see whether (i) it tells us something about the *subject itself*, or (ii) it refers to *somebody or something that is different and separate from the subject*.

  If it tells us something about the subject itself, it is not an object.

  If it refers to somebody or something that is separate or different from the subject, it is an object.

Note that when a verb tells us that something is being done to a person or thing, the verb cannot have an object, for the simple reason that the subject *does not act*:

(v) *Our* ***meals*** *are cooked by Mother.*

(w) *The* ***child*** *was bitten by a snake.*

(x) *The* ***car*** *will be driven by Karim.*

In these sentences, the subjects are not *doers*—they *do not do, have not done* or *will not do* anything. On the contrary, something is being done to them.

action

subject ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← ← **verb**

If the subject does not act, its action cannot affect anybody or anything directly. So, the verb cannot have an object. Therefore, in sentences like *(v)*, *(w)* and *(x)*, the verbs—*are cooked, was bitten,* or *will be driven*—cannot have an object.

A ***Pick out the verbs from the following sentences and say whether they are transitive or intransitive. Point out the subject of each verb and the object of a transitive verb.***

1. Jaya was sleeping soundly.
2. Maya loves flowers.
3. He has written many poems on spring.
4. Birds have built their nests in that tree.
5. Sunflowers are yellow in colour.
6. Ravi has put your books on the table.
7. These dishes have been cooked by my sister.
8. We shall never forget your kindness.
9. Raveena purchased some vegetables from the market.
10. Which chapters has your new teacher taught you?
11. The blue sea sparkled in the sun.
12. The match was won easily by our team.
13. Why have you not polished your shoes?
14. The snake slid into a hole.
15. A speech was delivered by our Principal on Independence Day.

Direct and Indirect Objects

Some transitive verbs can take two objects: a *direct object* and an *indirect object*.

(y) *The students gave their teacher some flowers.*

(z) *Kitty wrote Veena a letter.*

(aa) *A library lends people books.*

(ab) *The explorer gave the zoo a rare bird that he had caught.*

(y) The students gave *what?* Ans: *flowers*
The students gave *whom?* Ans: *teacher*

The verb *gave,* therefore, has two objects: *flowers* and *teacher*.

The answer to *what* gives us the direct object: *flowers.*

The answer to *whom* gives us the indirect object: *teacher.*

Or, in other words, the *thing* that is given—*flowers*—is called the direct object.

The *person* to whom it is given—*teacher*—is called the indirect object.

(z) Kitty wrote *what?* Ans: *letter*—direct object
Kitty wrote *whom* a letter? Ans: *Veena*—indirect object

Here also, the direct object is the *thing* written—letter.

The indirect object is the *person* to whom it was written—Veena.

(aa) A library lends *what?* Ans: *books*—direct object
A library lends books to *whom?* Ans: *people*—indirect object

Note again that the direct object is the *thing* lent—*books*—and the indirect object is *people*—the *persons*—to whom they are lent.

The direct object is usually a non-living thing. The indirect object is usually a person, animal or living thing. However, there can be exceptions:

(ab) *The explorer gave the zoo a rare bird that he had caught.*
Here, *bird,* a living thing, is the direct object, and *zoo,* a non-living thing, the indirect object.

Remember that when a verb has only one object, the terms *direct object* and *indirect object* are not used—we simply call that one object, the *object*.

B ***Pick out the verbs from the following sentences. Point out (a) their subjects and (b) objects, if any. In the case of transitive verbs with more than one object, mention which are direct and which indirect objects.***

1. The Fairy Queen gave the princess two gifts.
2. The gardener has planted many flowering bushes.
3. Some of the flowers in the pots were red and violet.
4. The police asked the guards many questions about the robbery.
5. Grandma told us a frightening story of ghosts and demons.
6. The hive was full of honey.
7. The rooms have been decorated for the party tonight.
8. All the boys seemed happy and cheerful.
9. We shall come back home before evening.
10. Do not give your dog soft bones.
11. Who can count all the stars in the sky?
12. My friends gave me a box of chocolates on my birthday.
13. The weather here has now become very pleasant.
14. Rita cooked us a delicious meal.
15. This picture has been painted by Meena.
16. The poet gave his poem a long title.
17. Soon after the earthquake, the villagers rebuilt the entire village.
18. Please give me a cup of coffee.
19. We were taught English grammar by our father.
20. Our father taught us English grammar.